

Hackathon & Smart India Hackathon (SIH) Judging Criteria

The table below is synthesized from multiple Smart India Hackathon internal evaluation rubrics, SIH guidelines, university evaluation sheets, and judging frameworks used across major hackathons. Although the exact weightage differs between events, these are the parameters that consistently determine winners.

#	Judging Criterion	What Judges Look For	Common Questions Judges Ask	Weight (Typical)	How to Score High
1	Problem Understanding	Clear understanding of the real-world problem	Why does this problem exist? Who faces it? How serious is it?	★★★★★	Start with real data, statistics, user pain points and existing gaps.
2	Innovation / Novelty	Originality of the solution	What makes your idea different? Why hasn't this been solved already?	★★★★★★	Show unique features instead of combining existing tools.
3	Technical Complexity	Engineering difficulty and technical depth	What's technically challenging here?	★★★★★★	Use meaningful architecture, AI, distributed systems, optimization, etc., only when justified.
4	Technical Feasibility	Whether the solution can actually be built	Can this realistically work? Is the technology mature enough?	★★★★★★	Demonstrate a working MVP with a realistic implementation roadmap.
5	Architecture & System Design	Backend, frontend, APIs, scalability	Why did you choose this architecture?	★★★★★	Use clean modular architecture diagrams with proper reasoning.

6	Implementation Quality	Working prototype and execution	Is it actually built or only an idea?	★★★★★★	A polished MVP always scores higher than an unfinished ambitious idea.
7	User Experience (UX/UI)	Ease of use and design	Can a first-time user understand it immediately?	★★★★★	Keep interfaces simple, consistent and intuitive.
8	Impact	Social, industrial or economic benefit	Who benefits? How many users can it help?	★★★★★★	Quantify potential impact with measurable outcomes.
9	Scalability	Ability to serve more users	Can this scale from 100 users to 1 million?	★★★★★	Discuss cloud infrastructure, databases and deployment strategy.
10	Practicality	Real-world usability	Can organizations adopt this tomorrow?	★★★★★	Explain deployment, onboarding and operational workflow.
11	Sustainability	Long-term viability	Will people continue using it after the hackathon?	★★★★	Cover maintenance, costs and long-term roadmap.
12	Business Viability	Revenue or operational sustainability	Who pays? How does this survive financially?	★★★★	Present a simple business or adoption model.
13	Future Scope	Expandability	What comes next after Version 1?	★★★★	Present a realistic roadmap rather than vague ideas.

1 4	Presentation Skills	Storytelling and confidence	Can the team explain everything clearly?	★★★★★	Follow a logical flow instead of reading slides.
1 5	Demo Quality	Live demonstration	Does it actually work?	★★★★★★	Keep the demo short, stable and focused on the core value.
1 6	Q&A Handling	Technical confidence	Can the team defend every decision?	★★★★★	Every member should know architecture, APIs, database and trade-offs.
1 7	Team Collaboration	Balanced contribution	Did everyone contribute?	★★★★	Clearly define individual roles during the presentation.
1 8	Documentation	PPT, diagrams, README	Is everything easy to understand?	★★★★	Use architecture diagrams, workflows and concise documentation.

What SIH Evaluators Usually Score

Across most Smart India Hackathon internal rounds, these parameters repeatedly appear:

SIH Evaluation Parameter	Description
Novelty of Idea	Originality and innovation
Complexity	Technical challenge involved
Clarity	Problem explanation and presentation
Feasibility	Can it actually be implemented?
Practicability	Can users adopt it?

Sustainability	Long-term usefulness
Scale of Impact	Number of beneficiaries and value created
User Experience	Ease of use and interface quality
Future Work	Expansion possibilities
Team Collaboration & Presentation	Communication and teamwork

Universal Judging Formula

After reviewing SIH rubrics, university evaluation sheets and international hackathon scorecards, almost every judge is subconsciously evaluating projects using this framework:

Area	Approx. Importance
Problem & Impact	20%
Innovation	20%
Technical Execution	25%
Feasibility & Scalability	15%
Demo & User Experience	10%
Presentation & Q&A	10%

Hidden Factors That Often Decide Winners

These are rarely written in official rubrics but are frequently mentioned by experienced judges and participants:

Hidden Factor	Why It Matters
Working MVP	A functional product consistently beats a great idea without implementation.
Fast Demo	Judges have limited time and appreciate concise demonstrations.

Clear Architecture Diagram	Makes complex systems easy to understand quickly.
Real User Validation	Interviews, surveys or pilot users increase credibility.
Performance Metrics	Benchmarks, latency and accuracy build confidence.
Clean GitHub & Documentation	Indicates engineering maturity.
Confident Q&A	Strong answers often separate finalists from winners.
Defined Team Roles	Demonstrates effective collaboration.
Backup Demo Video	Protects against internet or technical failures.

Winning Checklist (100/100 Project)

Criterion	✓
Solves a real problem	☐
Clearly innovative	☐
Working MVP	☐
Strong technical architecture	☐
Excellent UI/UX	☐
Real-world feasibility	☐
Scalable solution	☐
Measurable impact	☐
Future roadmap	☐
Smooth live demo	☐
Strong presentation	☐
Every member can answer questions	☐
Complete documentation	☐
Deployment or hosted prototype	☐
Business or adoption strategy	☐

This consolidated rubric closely reflects how SIH internal screenings, SIH-style evaluations, and many national hackathons assess projects, making it a practical benchmark for both participants and judges.